

A TRIPTYCH ARTICLE

Ontological Vertigo

On Being Held in Being

The Creature Before God — Part I

Contents

1	The Song and the House	1
2	What the Greeks Reached	1
3	What a Thing Is, and That It Is	2
4	The Present Tense of Creation	3
5	This Is True of Me	4
6	The Reading That Recoils	5
7	Consent, and the Shape of the Gift	6
	Notes	7
A	Scope, Method, and Qualifications	9
B	References	11
C	Generation Metadata	12

1 The Song and the House

A house outlives its builder. Once the last nail is driven, the carpenter can put down his hammer, walk away, retire, die; the house stands. Whatever it now needs—sound joists, dry rot kept at bay, a planet that continues to hold it down—it does not need *him*. His causing was spent in the making, and the made thing keeps the effect after the cause has gone.

A song is otherwise. It exists only while someone is singing it. The singer is not a manufacturer who could hand the finished product its independence; she is more like a spring than a mason, and the song stands to her the way the fountain's arc stands to the pressure beneath it. Stop the singing and there is no song-shaped thing left over to persist on its own. There is just silence, immediately.

These are both dependencies, but they are not the same dependency. The house depends on its builder for *coming to be*; the song depends on its singer for *being at all, now*. Philosophers mark the difference as one between a cause of becoming and a cause of being. Everyday life supplies endless examples of the first kind: parents and children, cooks and dinners, legislatures and laws. Examples of the second kind are rarer and easy to overlook, because the cause and the effect are simultaneous and the dependence shows itself only negatively—in what happens the instant the cause stops. Light in a room is the classic case. The lamp is not a builder that once installed brightness in the air and may now be switched off with no loss; the air is bright only while the lamp is shining into it. Brightness is not a possession the air acquired. It is a loan called in the moment the lending stops.

Now take the question one level down. A thing's shape, temperature, motion, color, and position all admit of both sorts of dependence, and we sort them case by case without much difficulty. But underneath all of these sits the fact that is so familiar it is hard to hold in focus: the thing *exists*. Not “exists” as shorthand for its features, but the blunt fact that there is something there to have features. And about existence itself the two models pose a question that ordinary experience does not settle. Is existing like the house—something a thing was given once, at the start, and now simply carries on with, no sustaining cause required? Or is it like the song and the lit air—something exercised now, and therefore either self-supplied now or received now?

Notice what the question is not. It is not a question about the past. Nothing in it asks whether the world had a beginning, how long ago, or what banged. A house built from eternity would still be house-like in its independence; a song sung from eternity would still be song-like in its dependence. The question is about the present tense of existence: tonight, at this hour, does anything stand under the fact that things *are*?

There is a perfectly serious answer available on the house side, and it deserves to be named before anything is argued, because much of what follows is an argument against it. On this view, existence needs a cause, if at all, only for its arrival. Once a thing exists, existing is simply what it does; persistence is the default, requiring no more explanation than a moving body's continued motion requires a continuous pusher. Contemporary philosophers call this *existential inertia*, and it is not a foolish position. Physics itself was born partly from the discovery that motion, which Aristotle thought needed a sustaining mover, keeps itself going quite well. Why should being be different?

Whether being is different is the whole matter. The inertia picture quietly treats existence as a state a thing can be in and then remain in, the way a body remains in uniform motion—as if *that a thing is* were one more of its features, the steadiest one. The alternative picture treats existence as more verb than state: something a thing is *doing*, or better, something being done in it, all the way down and all the time. Between these two pictures common sense has no vote to cast, because both are compatible with everything a day's experience contains. Houses stand, songs end, lamps switch off, and nothing in the furniture of the world wears a label announcing which model applies to the furniture itself.

Deciding between them requires instruments of an older kind: distinctions. The sharpest ones available were ground over about two thousand years, beginning in Greece, and the honest way to the question is through them—not because antiquity confers authority, but because the Greeks got there first with the fewest assumptions, and what they saw, and what they failed to see, marks the trail for everyone after.

2 What the Greeks Reached

Aristotle's contribution begins with an observation about change so plain that its power is easy to miss. Whatever changes acquires something it did not have: the cold water becomes hot, the seed becomes an oak, the unlit lamp

lights. Before the change, the thing possessed the new state only as a capacity—Aristotle says *potentially*; after, it possesses the state in fact—*actually*. And nothing confers on itself what it does not have. The water cannot heat itself; something already hot, or already in act in the relevant way, must do it. Potency does not lift itself into act, any more than an empty pocket funds a purchase. So every change points away from the changing thing to something actual; and Aristotle argues at length that actuality is prior to potency—in definition, and in the decisive sense in being: the capable exists for the sake of the achieved, and behind every capacity stands something already in act that awakens it.¹

Follow that pointing finger through a series. The water is heated by the fire, the fire sustained by its fuel and air, and so on. Where the members of such a series act *simultaneously*—each moving only because something is now moving it, like the last car of a train drawn by the car ahead—the series cannot do without a first member whose actuality is not on loan. Deferral is not explanation; a chain of borrowers, however long, never adds up to an owner. Aristotle drew the conclusion in the twelfth book of the *Metaphysics*: “there is a mover which moves without being moved, being eternal, substance, and actuality.” And then, in a sentence whose reach exceeds its grammar, he added: “On such a principle, then, depend the heavens and the world of nature.”² *Depend* is his word. The world of nature, for Aristotle, is not a house standing after its builder; it hangs, now, from pure actuality.

Plato had already reached a structurally similar result from a different side. What strikes him is not change but multiplicity: many beautiful things, no one of which is beauty. Each is beautiful in some respect, for a while, from an angle; each has beauty the way a borrower has money. In the *Phaedo* Socrates offers what he calls the safest answer to the question why anything is beautiful: “nothing makes a thing beautiful but the presence and participation of beauty,” so that “by beauty all beautiful things become beautiful.”³ Strip the example and keep the structure: whatever possesses a perfection partially, derivatively, and in company with many others that possess it too, points beyond itself to something that does not *have* that perfection but simply *is* it. The many borrow; somewhere stands what is not a borrower. Later thinkers would ask the obvious next question—what happens when the perfection in question is not beauty or equality but existence itself?—and the shape of Plato’s answer was waiting for them.

It matters, for honesty and for everything that follows, to state precisely what the Greeks did *not* conclude. Aristotle’s unmoved mover is an explanation of motion, not of being. It moves the heavens the way the beloved moves the lover—as an object of desire—and there is no suggestion that it chose the world, knows the world’s particulars, or gave the world existence; the cosmos alongside it is eternal, underived, and simply there. Plato’s forms are patterns, not makers; where a maker appears in his story, in the *Timaeus*, it is a craftsman god who shapes materials he did not produce, looking at a model he did not invent. Neither philosopher has any notion of a cause that supplies *that things exist at all*. Creation from nothing is not a Greek idea; it was not rejected by the Greeks, merely never conceived.⁴

And yet the instruments were now on the table. A distinction between potency and act, sharp enough to show that nothing actualizes itself. A logic of essentially ordered series, strong enough to show that simultaneous dependence must terminate in something that depends on nothing. A grammar of participation, supple enough to describe having-by-borrowing and to posit, at the source, one that is what the others merely have. What remained was to aim all three at the fact the Greeks never isolated: existence. That took a different intellectual world—one which had reasons of its own, not derived from philosophy, for suspecting that to exist is to be given.

3 What a Thing Is, and That It Is

The world that inherited the Greek instruments professed, on entirely non-philosophical grounds, that the whole of things had been called out of nothing. Whether that profession is true is not the present question, and nothing in this section will assume it. But it explains a change of focus. Thinkers who confessed creation had a standing reason to ask the question Athens never isolated—what accounts for there being anything to move?—and to ask it with Greek rigor. The thirteenth century, and Thomas Aquinas in particular, brought the two inheritances into one argument.

Aquinas’s decisive move is a distinction so quiet it can be missed. Consider any definable thing—a horse, a hexagon, a helium atom. Everything that belongs to *what it is* can be laid out in the definition, and the definition will be complete without ever mentioning *that it is*. You can know exhaustively what a thing would be while its existence remains an open question; naturalists have written precise descriptions of animals that turned out not to exist, and physicists of particles that turned out to exist after all. In no case did learning the answer add a new clause to the definition. Therefore what a thing is and that it is are really distinct in every such thing: essence does not include

existence, any more than the blueprint of the house includes the house's standing there. A thing's nature is related to its existing as a capacity to what fills it—which is to say, in Aristotle's currency, as potency to act.⁵

Once that distinction is in hand, the Greek machinery engages it with a click. Nothing confers on itself what it does not have; a nature that does not include existence cannot be the source of its own existing. Existence must then be received—and received the way the song is received from the singer, not the way the house was received from the builder, because the receiving is not an event in the thing's past but the present condition of there being a thing. Aquinas says it in the vocabulary Plato minted: “all beings apart from God are not their own being, but are beings by participation,” and whatever has a perfection by participation is caused in it by what has that perfection essentially, “as iron becomes ignited by fire.”⁶ At the head of the series of borrowers—and only there—stands something whose essence *is* its existence: not one more thing that happens to exist, but subsistent existence itself, having nothing in it of the unfilled capacity that would need, in turn, to be filled. Aquinas's name for the terminus is blunt: in God alone essence and existence are identical; God is “not only His own essence. . . but also His own existence.”⁷

The most famous compression of this reasoning is the first of Aquinas's five ways, and it is worth seeing both for what it says and for what it refuses to say. It begins not in speculation but in the street: “It is certain, and evident to our senses, that in the world some things are in motion.” Whatever is moved is moved by another; a simultaneous series of moved movers cannot regress without end; “therefore it is necessary to arrive at a first mover, put in motion by no other; and this everyone understands to be God.”⁸ Note the closing clause carefully. It does not claim that the argument has proved everything the word “God” carries; it reports that what the argument reaches—a first actuality on which the rest presently depends—occupies the place that common usage assigns to God. The heavy lifting of identification comes after, in the long analysis that shows the first terminus must be unique, simple, unlimited, and identical with its own being. A reader who accepts the First Way has not yet been given divine freedom, knowledge, or love; those are separate arguments, and this essay will take up only one of them.

And one door must be closed at once, because leaving it ajar corrupts everything downstream. None of this reasoning concerns the age of the world. Aquinas himself held—against friends and against apologetic convenience—that philosophy cannot demonstrate that the world began: “By faith alone do we hold, and by no demonstration can it be proved, that the world did not always exist.”⁹ An everlasting world would still be a borrowing world. The dependence at issue is vertical, not horizontal: not a chain of yesterdays reaching back to a first yesterday, but the present suspension of every existing thing from what exists of itself. The Greek sentence was right and only needed its full weight: on such a principle *depend*—present tense—the heavens and the world of nature.

4 The Present Tense of Creation

If existence is received the way the song is received, then the receiving has no expiration. Aquinas faces the point directly in the question he devotes to whether creatures need to be kept in being, and his answer is the song, not the house: “the being of every creature depends on God, so that not for a moment could it subsist, but would fall into nothingness were it not kept in being by the operation of the Divine power.”¹⁰ His illustration is the one this essay has been using since its first page. The sun does not build brightness into the air and move on; “the light in the air is by the continual influence of the sun,” and every creature stands to God “as the air is to the sun which enlightens it.” The sun has light by nature; the air is bright by sharing something not its own. So God alone is being by essence, “whereas every creature has being by participation.”¹¹

Two consequences follow, and both matter later.

First, this dependence is not a defect that better engineering could remove. Aquinas presses the thought to its limit: God could not make a creature that would keep existing after the divine sustaining ceased, “as neither can He make it not to have received its being from Himself.”¹² A self-sufficient creature is not a rarity; it is a contradiction, like a borrowed loan that belongs to the borrower. To be a creature *is* to be the receiving.

Second, the sustaining cause is not far away, watching its effect from outside. What is most one's own in any thing is its existence—“existence is that which is innermost in each thing and most fundamentally inherent in all things,” Aquinas writes—and since existence is precisely what is being given, the giver is present at the very point of the gift: “God is in all things, and innermost,” present to each thing as long as it has any being to be present to.¹³ Distance would make the picture easier—a deist clockmaker is a comfortable landlord—but the argument will not permit it. The nearer you go to the core of any creature, the nearer you are to the act by which God is holding it.

None of this was invented in the thirteenth century. Long before the scholastic vocabulary existed, Christian writers had said the same thing in their own registers, and it is worth hearing two of them, because they show that present-tense conservation is not a Thomistic refinement but the common ancient conviction. Irenaeus of Lyons, in the second century, answering people who thought souls were natively immortal: the heavens and everything made “continue throughout a long course of time according to the will of God,” and “life does not arise from us, nor from our own nature; but it is bestowed according to the grace of God.”¹⁴ Athanasius, in the fourth, stating the ground rule of all created natures: “the nature of created things, inasmuch as it is brought into being out of nothing, is of a fleeting sort, and weak and mortal, if composed of itself only”—and therefore the Word of God, “quickening and sustaining all things everywhere,” holds the universe in existence at every moment.¹⁵

The Catholic Church has fixed this conviction in her most deliberate registers, and honesty about method requires saying plainly what kind of claim that is. The First Vatican Council teaches that the one true God, “by an absolutely free plan” (*liberrimo consilio*), created both orders of creatures out of nothing—and created not from need: “not for increasing his own beatitude, nor for acquiring it, but to manifest his perfection through the goods he imparts to creatures.”¹⁶ The Catechism condenses conservation into one sentence: “With creation, God does not abandon his creatures to themselves. He not only gives them being and existence, but also, and at every moment, upholds and sustains them in being, enables them to act and brings them to their final end.”¹⁷ Notice that the dogmatic sentences say *more* than the philosophy proved. That the sustaining source is *free*—that the world is chosen, not exuded—and that the sustaining is aimed at an end, are teachings the Church holds from revelation. The philosophical argument delivered present dependence on subsistent being; it did not, by itself, deliver a giver who could have refrained. Keeping that seam visible is not pedantry. It is the difference between an ascent and a sermon.

So the picture stands complete on its two supports, argued and attested: existence is not a possession but a present reception; the receiving has no intermission; the giver is nearer to each thing than its own innermost parts, and gains nothing by the transaction. Stated so, in the third person, about horses and hexagons and helium, it is a tidy piece of metaphysics—interesting, orderly, cold to the touch. It stops being cold at the moment of a small grammatical substitution that the whole argument has been quietly licensing all along. Every premise that applied to *things* applies to the one reading this sentence.

5 This Is True of Me

Make the substitution slowly, because speed is the usual way of escaping it.

I exist. Not as a premise borrowed from Descartes—nothing here turns on proving it—but as the plain condition of my asking anything. My nature, like the horse’s and the hexagon’s, does not include existence: what I am could be exhaustively described by someone who did not know whether I had ever been born, as my grandparents in 1930 could have been described, completely, without a word about me. So my existing is not mine the way my triangularity would belong to a triangle. It is exercised in me now, and it is either self-supplied now or received now, and it is not self-supplied—nothing in the preceding argument allowed an exception for the arguer. At this instant, in the middle of this sentence, I am the lit air and not the lamp. I am being done.

The tradition has a word for what can happen at this point, and the word is not “conclusion.” Augustine, who made this discovery in the first person and wrote it down more nakedly than anyone before him, describes the double shock of it. The first shock is where the sustaining source turned out to be. Not far away, at the top of some ladder of beings, but closer to him than he was to himself: “You were more inward to me than my most inward part; and higher than my highest”—*interior intimo meo et superior summo meo*.¹⁸ The second shock is what he himself turned out to be. Turned toward what simply is, he registered his own manner of existing as if for the first time: “I trembled with love and fear; and I found myself to be far off from You, in the region of dissimilarity”; and of everything below God he saw that “they neither altogether are, nor altogether are not.”¹⁹ That is not a man learning a doctrine. That is a man losing his footing—finding that the floor he stands on is not floor but hand.

This essay proposes a name for the experience, and the name is a coinage, offered as such and attributed to no one: *ontological vertigo*. It means the reflexive apprehension of asymmetric dependence in the order of being—the arrest that occurs when the metaphysics of the preceding sections stops being about things and is recognized, by a particular knower, as the present truth about himself. Three clarifications keep the term honest. It is an act of intellect, not a required feeling; the trembling Augustine reports may accompany it or not, and nothing below argues from the sensation. It is not doubt; the vertigo is precisely proportional to how much one takes the argument to

have *succeeded*. And it is not rare in principle, only in practice, because the fact it apprehends is the most evenly distributed fact there is. What is rare is holding still for it. The knowledge that I do not hold myself in being is like the knowledge that I will die: universally available, structurally resisted, and transformed the moment it moves from the third person to the first.

Why *vertigo*? Because of the asymmetry, which is the part that ordinary talk of “depending on God” fails to convey. Dependencies we know are mutual, if only slightly. The nursing infant depends utterly on its mother—and the mother’s body, schedule, and heart are reorganized around the infant. Every creaturely relation has some return current. Here there is none, and Aquinas states it with a serenity that can read as coldness until it reads as the whole point: creatures are really related to God, “whereas in God there is no real relation to creatures, but a relation only in idea.”²⁰ The council said the same thing dogmatically: creation was not for increasing God’s beatitude, nor for acquiring anything. My existing adds nothing to what sustains my existing. The relation on which everything about me hangs makes, from the other side, no difference at all—not because the other side is indifferent in the way of a negligent father, but because it is already the fullness that a difference would have to be added to. I am, at this moment, wholly suspended from what I cannot inconvenience, enrich, threaten, repay, or affect. The infant at least kicks. Before God I cannot even kick, since the kicking, too, is on loan.

Vertigo, then, in the strict sense: the ground’s refusal to push back. A physical fall at least ends; this is the discovery that, ontologically, I am always falling—and that the falling is called existing, and that it is painless, ordinary, and sustained on purpose from underneath. What a mind does in the seconds after seeing this is, in miniature, the whole religious question, and the options are exactly two.

6 The Reading That Recoils

The first option is to experience the asymmetry as an assault and to pull away from it. Call this *recoil*—another term this essay defines for its own use. Recoil is not the initial lurch, the trembling Augustine felt; a shudder is not a position. Recoil is what the shudder becomes when it hardens into a reading: the interpretation of total dependence as a threat to one’s own reality, met with the will’s withdrawal. Its inner voice is easy to transcribe. *If my existence is on loan at every instant, then I am not real in my own right. If everything in me is received, then nothing in me is mine—not my acts, which are powered from elsewhere; not my achievements, which are gifts wearing my name; not even my refusal, which uses borrowed breath. A dependence that absolute is indistinguishable from annihilation with extra steps. Better to look away; better still to resent it.*

The transcription deserves respect, because it is not stupid. It correctly registers the scale of what the argument showed and refuses the anesthetic of half-measures—the polite theism in which God made us long ago and now we are mostly on our own. Recoil has, at least, done the metaphysics. Its one load-bearing assumption is that God and the creature occupy the same causal floor, so that whatever is attributed to one must be subtracted from the other. On that picture, agency is a pie; if God supplies my existing and my acting, my slice is zero, and “I” names a puppet with unusually complete strings.

But the same-floor picture is precisely what the argument ruled out. The sun and the eye do not compete to explain seeing; the eye sees *because* the sun pours in light—remove the light and you do not liberate the eye, you blind it. The singer and the song do not split the credit for the melody; the song’s whole reality is the singer’s gift, and the gift is precisely *the song’s own existing*. What God causes, in causing me, is not a rival version of my acts; it is *me, acting*. The Catechism’s sentence had the structure exactly: God upholds creatures in being and thereby “enables them to act.”²¹ Existence-from-another is not existence-minus. It is the only kind of existence a creature could have, and it is entirely, non-metaphorically existence: the air is really bright, the iron really burns. To feel subtracted-from by the discovery that one is sustained is like feeling plagiarized by one’s own reflection. Nothing has been taken. There was never a prior, independent self whose holdings were confiscated; there is a self at all because the holding never stops.

The tradition’s name for living inside the corrected picture is not servility but two virtues that recoil misreads as one vice. Aquinas: toward any difficult good, two dispositions are needed—one “to temper and restrain the mind, lest it tend to high things immoderately,” which is humility, and one “to strengthen the mind against despair, and urge it on to the pursuit of great things according to right reason,” which is magnanimity.²² They respond to two true facts about the same creature. Humility answers the fact that nothing in me is from me—the exact fact the vertigo disclosed. Magnanimity answers the fact that what has been given to me is genuinely great and genuinely operative: “There is in man something great which he possesses through the gift of God; and something defective,” and each

estimate is owed its own honesty.²³ Humility without magnanimity curdles into the self-contempt that calls itself piety and is really a last bid for self-manufacture—if *I cannot be my own source, I will at least be my own accuser*. Magnanimity without humility inflates into the fantasy of aseity that the vertigo just demolished. Together they are simply the truth, held steady: everything received; the received thing real and great.

Recoil, in other words, is not refuted so much as diagnosed. It is right that the asymmetry is total and right that no dignity could survive it *if dependence were rivalry*. It goes wrong at the picture, and the picture, once seen, can be exchanged; the facts cannot. The creature that finishes reading the diagnosis is exactly as suspended as before, lit air in a universe of lit air. The remaining question is whether the other reading can be held with open eyes, and what it finds if it looks up the beam.

7 Consent, and the Shape of the Gift

The second option is consent: the will's agreement with what the intellect saw. Not resignation, which agrees the way a prisoner agrees with the wall, and not optimism, which agrees by not looking. Consent says: it is true that I do not hold myself in being, and I am willing that it be true.

Consent sounds passive and is not, because of what it consents *to*. Look again at the structure left standing. The source sustains everything and gains nothing. It cannot gain: no return current, no real relation back. Now ask what kind of giving that is—the question recoil never stays to ask. Among creatures we know it only in traces—the mother of a newborn who can know nothing of her, the craftsman perfecting a joint no inspector will ever see. Giving that expects no return we call love; here the absence of return is not an ethical achievement but a metaphysical necessity—and the giving happens anyway, at every point of being, at every moment, and could stop and does not.

Aquinas turns this observation into a formal judgment—the summit of what unaided reason can say here. God loves all existing things, he argues—and divine love differs from ours in the direction of causality. Our love is awakened by goodness already there; “the love of God infuses and creates goodness” in things.²⁴ To love is to will good to something; to exist at all is already to be receiving good—being, the good under every other good—from a will that nothing necessitated. The council's phrase, quoted earlier as dogma, can now be heard as the exact converse of the vertigo: creation was *not for increasing his own beatitude*. What made the arrest dizzying was that my existence makes no difference to God. What consent discovers inside the same fact is that my existence was therefore never extracted, owed, or useful—that it can only have been *given*. The asymmetry that looked like an abyss is the signature of gift. No one holds a debtor in being gratuitously, at every instant, innermost, forever, for nothing. The falling was never falling. It was being carried.

Two restraints keep this conclusion from saying more than it knows. First, “loves” is an analogical word. The judgment that God loves all things is a judgment about what God does—wills and causes good—reached by argument; it is not a window into what loving is *for God*, and natural reason cannot make it one. The inner life of God is closed to the ascent: Aquinas is categorical that “it is impossible to attain to the knowledge of the Trinity by natural reason,”²⁵ and the essay's philosophical thread ends there. Second, even the surviving words must be handled as the tradition's masters handled them—as true, and as breaking in the hand. The anonymous author who wrote as Dionysius, at the border of Greek philosophy and Christian prayer, counseled the mind ascending past every concept toward “Him Who is above every essence and knowledge”: in the end one says that the source “is neither soul, nor mind,” nor any of the things it gives—not because it is less than these, but because it is not one of the things that have.²⁶ Apophasis is not agnosticism; it is precision about a source the argument itself showed to be beyond the genus of borrowed things. The creature's best sentences about God are true the way a map is true of a country: reliably, and without resemblance.

So Part I closes at the fork it uncovered. A mind that follows the argument to its end stands arrested: wholly real, genuinely acting, and not for one instant self-possessed—held, innermost, by what it cannot repay and was never asked to. Recoil reads the holding as humiliation and is wrong about the picture, not the scale. Consent reads it as gift, has the better of the argument, and finds that its natural terminus is not a proposition but a posture—the reverence the tradition calls adoration, owed to the excellence that gives and does not receive.²⁷ What that posture looks like when an embodied life—a creature of mornings, obligations, and a body—takes it up is the matter of Part II; what the source has revealed about itself beyond the ascent's reach, and what it makes of creatures who consent, is the matter of Part III. The present essay claims what it argued: that the vertigo is the truth; that the truth was never a threat; and that the ground beneath the falling creature is not ground but hands, and always was.

Notes

¹Aristotle, *Metaphysics* IX (Θ), ch. 8 (1049b–1050b): “actuality is prior to potency,” prior “in formula” and “in substantial being”; “one actuality always precedes another in time right back to the actuality of the eternal prime mover.” Quoted from the public-domain translation of W. D. Ross, *The Works of Aristotle Translated into English*, vol. VIII: *Metaphysica* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1908); wording checked 2026-07-24 in an Internet Archive scan of the 1908 printing.

²Aristotle, *Metaphysics* XII (Λ), ch. 7 (1072b), Ross translation as above; wording checked 2026-07-24. The train image and the borrower image are this essay’s, not Aristotle’s; they illustrate what the scholastics later called an essentially ordered causal series, in which each member’s causing exists only while the prior member is causing.

³Plato, *Phaedo* 100c–e, in the public-domain translation of Benjamin Jowett; wording checked 2026-07-24 at Project Gutenberg (ebook no. 1658). The safest-answer passage belongs to Socrates’ account of his “second sailing”; its generalization from beauty to being is the later Platonic and Christian-Platonic development, not a claim of the dialogue itself.

⁴This paragraph states the standard scholarly boundary rather than a controversial reading: the mover of *Metaphysics* XII moves as final cause (“as beloved,” 1072b); the Demiurge of the *Timaeus* orders pre-existing materials toward an eternal model. Neither text contains creation *ex nihilo* or a freely willed world. The point is not a defect of intelligence but of question: the Greek arguments answer “why is there motion?” and “why are there many so-and-sos?”—not “why is there anything?”

⁵The essence–existence distinction is stated compactly in Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 3, a. 4, and presupposed throughout qq. 3–11; its fuller derivation is in the early opusculum *De ente et essentia*, ch. 4, which this essay does not separately cite. English quotations from the *Summa* throughout are from the public-domain translation of the Fathers of the English Dominican Province; Latin checked in the Corpus Thomisticum web corpus. Both witnesses checked 2026-07-24. The real distinction in creatures is the adopted framework of this essay and of broad Thomistic tradition, not a dogma binding every Catholic school; Scotist and Suarezian accounts differ, and the argument of the following sections needs only what the distinction secures: that no finite nature accounts for its own existing.

⁶*Summa theologiae* I, q. 44, a. 1, corpus (“Therefore all beings apart from God are not their own being, but are beings by participation”; *omnia alia a Deo non sint suum esse, sed participant esse*); wording checked 2026-07-24, English at New Advent, Latin at Corpus Thomisticum. The iron-and-fire comparison is Aquinas’s own in the same corpus. Note the order of the article: by q. 44 the phrase “apart from God” has been earned by qq. 2–11; the present essay reproduces that order in compressed form, and the name “God” enters its own argument only as the last step of this section.

⁷*Summa theologiae* I, q. 3, a. 4, corpus (*Deus non solum est sua essentia... sed etiam suum esse*); checked 2026-07-24 as above.

⁸*Summa theologiae* I, q. 2, a. 3, corpus (*Prima autem et manifestior via est, quae sumitur ex parte motus... et hoc omnes intelligunt Deum*); checked 2026-07-24 as above. “Motion” (*motus*) here is the actualization of potency in general, not local motion only. The regress denied is the essentially ordered, presently operating series; the First Way takes no position on whether a temporally ordered series of past causes could regress forever.

⁹*Summa theologiae* I, q. 46, a. 2, corpus (*mundum non semper fuisse, sola fide tenetur, et demonstrative probari non potest*); checked 2026-07-24 as above. This essay therefore makes no first-moment or cosmological-beginning argument anywhere, and no conclusion below depends on one.

¹⁰*Summa theologiae* I, q. 104, a. 1, corpus (*esse cuiuslibet creaturae a Deo, ita quod nec ad momentum subsistere possent, sed in nihilum redigerentur, nisi operatione divinae virtutis conservarentur in esse*); wording checked 2026-07-24, English at New Advent, Latin at Corpus Thomisticum. Aquinas is quoting Gregory the Great’s *Moralia* for the formula and making it his own conclusion.

¹¹Same article and corpus; the sun-and-air comparison and the being-by-participation conclusion are Aquinas’s own wording in the Dominican translation. Conservation, on this account, is not a sequence of fresh creative acts or divine decisions but the non-interruption of the one act of giving being; the difference between creation and conservation is a difference in the effect’s history (beginning versus continuing), not in the divine action.

¹²*Summa theologiae* I, q. 104, a. 1 (“God cannot grant to a creature to be preserved in being after the cessation of the Divine influence: as neither can He make it not to have received its being from Himself”); checked 2026-07-24 as above.

¹³*Summa theologiae* I, q. 8, a. 1, corpus (*Esse autem est illud quod est magis intimum cuilibet, et quod profundius omnibus inest... unde oportet quod Deus sit in omnibus rebus, et intime*); checked 2026-07-24 as above. The presence asserted is causal presence by essence, power, and operation, not pantheistic identity: precisely because God gives being to what is *other* than God, the intimacy and the distinction rise together.

¹⁴Irenaeus, *Adversus haereses* II.34.3 (heavens, stars, and all created things continuing according to the will of God; life bestowed, not arising from our nature) and II.34.4 (the soul “partakes in that life bestowed upon her by God”); quoted from the Roberts–Rambaut translation in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1 (1885), wording checked 2026-07-24 at the New Advent transcription.

¹⁵Athanasius, *Contra Gentes* 41 (created nature, brought into being out of nothing, fleeting “if composed of itself only”) and 42 (the Word “quickening and sustaining all things everywhere”); quoted from the Robertson translation in *Nicene and*

Post-Nicene Fathers, 2nd series, vol. 4 (1892), wording checked 2026-07-24 at the New Advent transcription. For Athanasius the sustainer is specifically the Word—a claim of Christian confession, not of philosophical demonstration, and cited here as witness to the antiquity of the conservation conviction rather than as a premise.

¹⁶First Vatican Council, dogmatic constitution *Dei Filius* (24 April 1870), ch. 1 (*non ad augendam suam beatitudinem, nec ad acquirendam, sed ad manifestandam perfectionem suam per bona, quae creaturis impertitur, liberrimo consilio simul ab initio temporis utramque de nihilo condidit creaturam*), with the corresponding canon (*De Deo*... can. 5) condemning the claim that God created by necessity rather than by will free from all necessity. Latin checked 2026-07-24 at the Holy See web text; the English renderings here are a labeled working gloss governed by the quoted Latin. The council’s definition is received dogma, taught on the authority of revelation; the *freedom* of creation in particular goes beyond anything the philosophical argument of the preceding sections established.

¹⁷*Catechism of the Catholic Church* 301, official Vatican English web text, wording checked 2026-07-24; compare CCC 300 on transcendence and intimate presence, which quotes Augustine’s *Confessions* III.6.11. These are citations of the Church’s teaching as teaching; the philosophical ascent of sections 2–4 stands on its own arguments, and the reader who rejects those arguments is not being asked to accept their conclusion on conciliar authority smuggled in afterward.

¹⁸Augustine, *Confessions* III.6.11, in the Pilkington translation (*Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st series, vol. 1), wording checked 2026-07-24 at the New Advent transcription; Latin checked 2026-07-24 at the Latin Library text of Book III. The sentence is retrospective: Augustine is describing the God he had been seeking “according to the sense of the flesh” while the sought one was nearer than the seeking.

¹⁹Augustine, *Confessions* VII.10.16 (trembling “with love and fear”; *regio dissimilitudinis*, rendered “region of dissimilarity” by Pilkington) and VII.11.17 (“I viewed the other things below You, and perceived that they neither altogether are, nor altogether are not”); checked 2026-07-24 as above. Augustine’s scene includes elements—grace, scripture, moral crisis—far beyond the philosophical arrest this essay isolates; it is cited as the classic first-person record of that arrest, not as a proof of anything.

²⁰*Summa theologiae* I, q. 13, a. 7, corpus (“Since therefore God is outside the whole order of creation, and all creatures are ordered to Him, and not conversely, it is manifest that creatures are really related to God Himself; whereas in God there is no real relation to creatures, but a relation only in idea”; *in Deo non est aliqua realis relatio eius ad creaturas, sed secundum rationem tantum*); checked 2026-07-24, English at New Advent, Latin at Corpus Thomisticum. The technical claim is that creation adds no accident to God, effects no change in God, and constitutes God in no way; it does not mean that God’s knowing, willing, and loving of creatures are fictions—these are God’s own substance, not accidents caused in him by us.

²¹*Catechism of the Catholic Church* 301, checked 2026-07-24 as above. The underlying scholastic account—God as primary cause working in every secondary cause according to the creature’s own mode, so that the whole effect is God’s in one order and the creature’s in another—is developed in *Summa theologiae* I, q. 105, a. 5, which this essay summarizes without quoting. The compatibility of divine primary causality with genuine created freedom is a vast question treated here only to the extent the recoil argument requires: dependence in being does not subtract agency, because it is not one more agency alongside mine but the reason there is a mine.

²²*Summa theologiae* II-II, q. 161, a. 1, corpus (the twofold virtue regarding the difficult good), with a. 1, ad 5 (humility “regards chiefly the subjection of man to God”) and a. 2, corpus (humility as the restraint by which one is not “borne towards that which is above him” against right reason); checked 2026-07-24, English at New Advent, Latin at Corpus Thomisticum.

²³*Summa theologiae* II-II, q. 129, a. 3, ad 4; checked 2026-07-24 as above. Aquinas’s point is that magnanimity esteems the received gifts truly (and so tends to great works) while humility esteems the self’s non-aseity and defect truly; both “follow right reason,” so their coexistence in one person is not paradox but accuracy.

²⁴*Summa theologiae* I, q. 20, a. 2, corpus (“God loves all existing things”; “our love... is not the cause of its goodness; but conversely its goodness... calls forth our love... whereas the love of God infuses and creates goodness”; *amor Dei est infundens et creans bonitatem in rebus*); checked 2026-07-24, English at New Advent, Latin at Corpus Thomisticum. “Loves” is here an analogical predication: to love is to will good to something, and God wills and causes the good of every creature. The judgment is philosophical in Aquinas’s presentation; what love is in the divine inner life is not thereby disclosed.

²⁵*Summa theologiae* I, q. 32, a. 1, corpus; checked 2026-07-24 as above. That God is triune, and that the love reached analogically by reason is, in its own life, Father, Son, and Spirit, are truths of revelation; this essay’s argument neither reaches nor gestures at them, and the series to which it belongs takes them up only where revelation is explicitly on the table.

²⁶Pseudo-Dionysius, *Mystical Theology*, ch. 1 (the ascent to union “with Him Who is above every essence and knowledge”) and ch. 5 (“It is neither soul, nor mind...”); quoted from the public-domain Parker translation (1897), wording checked 2026-07-24 at the CCEL transcription. The author is an anonymous Christian writer of the late fifth or early sixth century, conventionally cited under his pseudonym; he is not the Athenian convert of Acts 17. Cited for apophatic restraint only: the denials mark the failure of creaturely categories at the source of categories, not a retraction of the analogical judgments made above.

²⁷On adoration as the act of reverence rendered to God alone on account of the divine excellence, see *Summa theologiae* II-II, q. 84, a. 1, and ad 1 (“Reverence is due to God on account of His excellence”); checked 2026-07-24 as above. The step from consent to adoration is here only named, not developed.

A Scope, Method, and Qualifications

A.1 Reader, question, and method

This is a discursive metaphysical and theological article for a serious general reader, able to follow careful distinctions but not presumed to know scholastic terminology. It is Part I of a three-part series, *The Creature Before God*; each part is a complete essay, and this one carries the series' foundation. Its governing question is what a creature apprehends when the metaphysics of received being is recognized as the present truth about the knower—the condition this essay names *ontological vertigo*—and whether that apprehension must end in recoil or can be consented to without self-deception. Its claim: existence in creatures is received, not possessed; the reception is presently and continuously sustained; the dependence is asymmetric, the sustaining source receiving nothing in return; recoil misreads this asymmetry through a same-floor rivalry picture that the argument itself rules out; and consent, reading the asymmetry as gift, terminates naturally in the analogical judgment that God loves all existing things—at which point natural reason reaches its boundary.

The argument proceeds in epistemic order: the becoming/being distinction and the existential-inertia alternative, stated without theological premises; the Aristotelian and Platonic instruments with their historical limits; the Thomistic essence–existence distinction, participation, and the First Way with its own stated limits; conservation and divine intimacy, argued philosophically and then attested by patristic and magisterial witnesses cited *as* received teaching; the reflexive turn, the coinage, and the one-sided real relation; the diagnosis of recoil; and consent, the analogical judgment of divine love, and apophatic restraint. Revealed claims (free creation, the Word as sustainer, Trinity) are labeled as received where they appear and are nowhere presented as conclusions of the philosophical ascent. English is the working language; no liturgical rite, civil or canonical jurisdiction, or mutable discipline governs any conclusion. All online witnesses were checked on 2026-07-24.

Source class	Function in the article	Governing boundary
Ancient philosophy	Aristotle supplies potency/act, the priority of actuality, and dependence on unmoved actuality; Plato supplies the participation structure.	Neither is credited with creation from nothing, free creation, or conservation; their limits are stated in the section that uses them.
Thomistic philosophy and theology	ST I, qq. 2–3, 8, 13, 20, 32, 44, 46, 104; II-II, qq. 84, 129, 161 govern the adopted metaphysical and moral framework.	Adopted as the article's framework where Catholic theology permits schools; not asserted as dogma; each locus is used at its exact argumentative level.
Patristic witness	Irenaeus and Athanasius attest the antiquity of present-tense conservation; Augustine supplies the first-person record of the arrest; Pseudo-Dionysius supplies apophatic restraint.	Witness to reception, not mechanical authority; Athanasius's sustaining <i>Word</i> is confessional, flagged as such; Dionysius is identified as pseudonymous.
Authoritative Catholic teaching	<i>Dei Filius</i> ch. 1 with canon 5 on free creation from nothing; CCC 300–301 on transcendence, intimacy, and conservation.	Cited as the Church's teaching, explicitly beyond what the philosophy proved; dogmatic force confined to what the texts state.
Project synthesis	The coined terms (ontological vertigo, recoil, consent as used here), the song/house and lit-air development, the transcription of recoil, and all final formulations.	Original editorial synthesis argued from the checked sources; attributed to no source and creating no doctrine.

A.2 Included and excluded scope

Included are: the distinction between causes of becoming and causes of being, with existential inertia named as the live alternative; Aristotle on potency, act, and the dependence of nature on pure actuality, and Plato on participation,

each with stated limits; the real distinction of essence and existence in creatures; being by participation and its causal principle; the First Way with its two limits (no proof of a temporal beginning; identification of the terminus as “God” deferred to further argument); conservation (ST I, q. 104, a. 1) and divine innermost presence (I, q. 8, a. 1); the patristic conservation witness of Irenaeus and Athanasius; the dogmatic teaching of free creation from nothing and the Catechism’s conservation paragraph; the reflexive first-person turn with Augustine’s record; the coinage and definition of ontological vertigo; the one-sided real relation (I, q. 13, a. 7); the diagnosis of recoil via noncompetitive causality; humility and magnanimity as jointly true estimates; consent; the analogical judgment that God loves all things (I, q. 20, a. 2); the natural-reason boundary at the Trinity (I, q. 32, a. 1); and apophatic restraint.

Excluded are: any argument from a temporal beginning of the universe (Kalam or otherwise); physical cosmology; a defense of every premise against every contemporary objection, including a full answer to existential-inertia and brute-fact positions; adjudication among Thomist, Scotist, Suarezian, and analytic accounts of the real distinction; the mechanics of divine concurrence and human freedom beyond what the recoil diagnosis requires; theodicy and the problem of evil; grace, mystical experience, and deification (reserved to Parts II–III); Trinitarian theology; and any claim about the psychology or culpability of particular persons.

A.3 Material qualifications

1. *Ontological vertigo*, *recoil*, and *consent* as used here are coined, reader-facing terms defined in the body. They are not received technical vocabulary and are attributed to no historical author.
2. The essay’s positive case presumes the success of the participation argument it compresses; existential inertia and brute-fact accounts are named as serious alternatives and are answered only to the extent of exhibiting the rival picture, not refuted exhaustively.
3. The First Way is presented with Aquinas’s own limits: it concerns essentially ordered, presently operating dependence; it does not prove a temporal beginning (ST I, q. 46, a. 2), and “this everyone understands to be God” is a report of usage whose justification lies in the subsequent questions, summarized here rather than executed.
4. Conservation is the non-interruption of the single act of giving being, not repeated creation or a succession of divine decisions; the essay’s “at every moment” language quantifies over creaturely time, not over acts in God.
5. Divine innermost presence (ST I, q. 8, a. 1) is causal presence, not pantheistic identity; Creator and creature remain really distinct, and participation does not make creatures parts, modes, or fragments of God.
6. The one-sided real relation (ST I, q. 13, a. 7) denies a creature-caused accident or change in God. It does not make divine knowledge, will, or love fictional, and the essay states this beside the claim.
7. The freedom of creation and its ordering to an end are received dogma (*Dei Filius*), not conclusions of the essay’s philosophical thread; the essay marks this seam explicitly where the council is quoted.
8. Athanasius attributes conservation to the Word and Irenaeus to God’s will and grace; both are cited as witnesses to the antiquity of the conservation conviction, not as philosophical premises, and their confessional content is flagged.
9. Augustine’s arrest scenes involve grace, scripture, and moral crisis beyond the philosophical apprehension this essay isolates; they are cited as the classic first-person record, not as demonstration, and no affective experience is made normative or required.
10. “God loves all existing things” (ST I, q. 20, a. 2) is an analogical philosophical judgment about what God wills and causes; it does not disclose the divine inner life, entail an emotion in God, or demonstrate the Trinity, which natural reason cannot attain (ST I, q. 32, a. 1).
11. Humility’s “nothing from oneself” concerns non-aseity, not worthlessness; magnanimity’s esteem of received gifts is not pride. Recoil is defined as a hardened interpretation, not as the initial shudder, and no judgment is made about the culpability of any person’s response.
12. Consent to creaturehood is agreement with a metaphysical truth. It is not quietism, submission to injustice, or supernatural faith; the step from consent to adoration is named, not developed, and its lived form is deferred to Part II.
13. Pseudo-Dionysius is an anonymous Christian author of the late fifth or early sixth century, not the convert of Acts 17; his denials are cited as apophatic method, not as retraction of the essay’s analogical conclusions.

14. The Greek limits paragraph states the standard scholarly reading of *Metaphysics* XII and the *Timaeus*; no claim is made that Plato or Aristotle anticipated Christian doctrine.

A.4 Notes, translations, rights, currentness, and review

The numbered Notes carry exact citations, edition and translation identifications, verification dates, and qualifications that would interrupt the argument; no indispensable premise lives only in a note. Aristotle is quoted from the public-domain Ross translation (1908); Plato from the public-domain Jowett translation; Aquinas from the public-domain English Dominican translation with Latin checked at Corpus Thomisticum; Augustine from the public-domain Pilkington translation (NPNF 1/1) with one Latin phrase checked at a public Latin text; Irenaeus from the public-domain Roberts–Rambaut translation (ANF 1); Athanasius from the public-domain Robertson translation (NPNF 2/4); Pseudo-Dionysius from the public-domain Parker translation (1897). *Dei Filius* is quoted from the Holy See’s Latin web text with labeled working glosses; the Catechism is quoted briefly from the official Vatican English web text with attribution. Scripture is not directly quoted. Official texts and third-party translations remain outside the project’s CC BY 4.0 grant; project-created prose, coinages, images, and organization are project content.

All online witnesses were checked on 2026-07-24; no mutable law or discipline is relied on. This revision received internal argumentative, source-consistency, quotation, rights, and production review by the authoring agent. Independent philosophical, patristic, Thomistic, theological, literary, and ecclesiastical review is outstanding; no imprimatur, nihil obstat, or ecclesiastical approval is claimed, and internal checking is not independent review.

B References

Ancient philosophy

- Aristotle, *Metaphysics* IX (Θ), ch. 8 (1049b–1050b, priority of actuality) and XII (Λ), ch. 7 (1072b, the unmoved mover; “on such a principle depend the heavens and the world of nature”); trans. W. D. Ross, *The Works of Aristotle Translated into English*, vol. VIII: *Metaphysica* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1908); public domain; wording checked 2026-07-24 in the Internet Archive scan of the 1908 printing.
- Plato, *Phaedo* 100c–e (participation; “by beauty all beautiful things become beautiful”); trans. Benjamin Jowett; public domain; wording checked 2026-07-24 at Project Gutenberg (ebook no. 1658).

Patristic witnesses

- Irenaeus of Lyons, *Adversus haereses* II.34.3–4 (creatures continue according to the will of God; life bestowed, not our own); trans. Alexander Roberts and W. H. Rambaut, *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1 (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing, 1885); public domain; checked 2026-07-24 at New Advent.
- Athanasius of Alexandria, *Contra Gentes* 41–42 (created nature fleeting of itself; the Word sustaining all things); trans. Archibald Robertson, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 2nd series, vol. 4 (1892); public domain; checked 2026-07-24 at New Advent.
- Augustine of Hippo, *Confessions* III.6.11 (*interior intimo meo*), VII.10.16 (the trembling arrest; region of dissimilarity), VII.11.17 (things neither altogether are nor are not); trans. J. G. Pilkington, *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, 1st series, vol. 1 (1887); public domain; checked 2026-07-24 at New Advent (Book III) and New Advent (Book VII); Latin phrase checked at The Latin Library.
- Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite, *Mystical Theology* chs. 1 and 5 (ascent above essence and knowledge; the concluding denials); trans. John Parker, *The Works of Dionysius the Areopagite* (London: James Parker, 1897); public domain; checked 2026-07-24 at CCEL.

Thomistic framework

- Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 2, a. 3 (the First Way); q. 3, a. 4 (essence and existence identical in God alone); q. 8, a. 1 (God innermost in all things); q. 13, a. 7 (the one-sided real relation); q. 20, a. 2 (God loves all existing things); q. 32, a. 1 (Trinity beyond natural reason); q. 44, a. 1 (beings by participation); q. 46, a. 2 (no demonstration of a temporal beginning); q. 104, a. 1 (conservation; the sun-and-air comparison); II-II, q. 84, a. 1 (adoration); q. 129, a. 3, ad 4 (magnanimity with humility); q. 161, aa. 1–2 (humility). English from the public-domain translation of the Fathers of the English Dominican Province via New Advent; Latin checked in the Corpus Thomisticum online corpus. All loci checked 2026-07-24; work, question, article, and division govern over either site’s presentation.

Authoritative Catholic witnesses

- First Vatican Council, dogmatic constitution *Dei Filius* (24 April 1870), ch. 1 on God the creator (*liberrimo consilio... de nihilo; non ad augendam suam beatitudinem*) with canon 5 *De Deo rerum omnium creatore*; Holy See Latin text, vatican.va, checked 2026-07-24. English renderings in this essay are labeled working glosses governed by the Latin.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 300–301 (transcendence and intimate presence; God upholds and sustains creation), official Vatican English web text, vatican.va, checked 2026-07-24.

C Generation Metadata

Last revised (UTC): 2026-07-24T23:17:18Z

Model: claude-fable-5; **unexposed:** reasoning-effort and sampling configuration

Agent/runtime: Anthropic Claude Code agent (research, drafting, typesetting, review); Claude Code CLI 2.1.219; **unexposed:** server revision

Reuse and rights. To the extent Triptych holds the rights, project-created content and design are licensed under CC BY 4.0. Scripture, liturgical or official texts, received prayers or hymns, quotations, fonts, and other third-party material retain their own status; public-domain material remains public domain. Identify changes. Attribution implies neither Triptych nor ecclesiastical approval. See `LICENSE` and `THIRD_PARTY.md` in the source.